



"Fueling Global Trade, Connecting Continents"

DDS MARINE WEEKLY

MARITIME INTELLIGENCE

T A N K E R S | E N E R G Y | S T S | C O M P L I A N C E

Insight. Safety. Excellence.

ISSUE 008

18 SEPTEMBER 2026

Published by DDS Maritime Intelligence

A Research & Market Intelligence Publication of DDS Marine Energy Services

• Malaysia / Southeast Asia Focus — Prepared for Professional Circulation •



Executive Market Dashboard

Market snapshot: data cut-off **Friday 18 September 2026** | Ship & Bunker, Integr8 Fuels, oilprice.com, Hellenic Shipping News, wire reporting and DDS Marine market intelligence

BRENT CRUDE

US\$105.56/bbl

▼ Ship & Bunker, 16 Sep close;
Integr8 settle 105.83 (17 Sep)

WTI CRUDE

US\$101.96/bbl

▼ Ship & Bunker; Integr8 98.10 is
the Sep contract — not directly
comparable

SINGAPORE VLSFO

US\$900–928/mt

▼ index 913.50; range, not a point
figure

FUJAIRAH VLSFO

US\$1,000–1,040/mt

▲ premium over Singapore now
US\$95–108/mt

GULF TANKER RATES

>US\$1m/day

▲ first time on record, per
Bloomberg/Baltic Exchange

SAUDI EAST-WEST PIPELINE

OFFLINE

▼ 3 pumping stations damaged; 5–
6 wk repair estimate

DDS VIEW — Two chokepoints are now in play. Hormuz remains contested, and this week Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline — the kingdom's only major crude route that bypasses Hormuz entirely — was confirmed to have three pumping stations damaged in a drone attack, with Reuters reporting repairs could take five to six weeks. The pipeline normally carries 4–5 million barrels a day, roughly 4–5% of global supply. Aramco is racing to restore half its capacity within days, but in the meantime Saudi Arabia is doing the one thing the pipeline was built to avoid: routing more crude back through Hormuz via ship-to-ship transfers, and selling up to 20 million barrels on the spot market this week. Tanker rates for Gulf pickups have broken US\$1 million a day for the first time on record. Against that backdrop, we are treating every bunker and freight figure in this issue as a range with a stated cut-off, not a single number — see Data Integrity & Methodology, overleaf.

This Week at a Glance

- **Second chokepoint down:** Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline (7m bpd capacity, 4–5m bpd normal flow) has three damaged pumping stations; full repair may take 5–6 weeks, partial restart possible within days.
- **Tanker rates break \$1m/day:** Bloomberg reported Gulf-pickup tanker rates as high as US\$1.035m/day, per Baltic Exchange data; Gulf of Oman–China business quoted around US\$644,000/day.
- **Second-hand values surge:** a second-hand VLCC now reportedly fetches ~US\$182m against ~US\$130m for a newbuild, per Argus.
- **Tanker cyberattack investigated:** the WSJ reports US authorities are investigating a suspected cyberattack on two tankers near Gibraltar en route to the US Gulf Coast.
- **Bunkers softening, Gulf premium widening:** global average VLSFO eased on the week even as the Fujairah–Singapore spread widened to US\$95–108/mt.



CEO Market Commentary

Capt. Dinesh Naidu KC — Founder & Chairman, DDS Marine Group

"We built a bypass for Hormuz. This week the bypass became a casualty too."

For six months the market has treated Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline as the sensible answer to Hormuz risk: a 7-million-barrel overland route that never has to touch the Strait. This week that assumption failed. Three pumping stations were confirmed damaged in last week's drone attack, and Reuters reports repairs could take five to six weeks. Aramco is scrambling to restore half of capacity within days, but the honest reading is that the market's only real Hormuz bypass is now itself a casualty of the war it was built to avoid.

The consequence is almost too neat to be comfortable: Saudi Arabia is now sending more crude back through Hormuz, via ship-to-ship transfers outside the Strait, precisely the outcome the pipeline existed to prevent. Tanker rates for Gulf pickups have broken US\$1 million a day for the first time we have seen recorded. Second-hand VLCCs are now worth more than newbuilds. None of that is a healthy market; it is the price of scarcity and danger, and it will show up in landed fuel costs for everyone downstream of it, including us.

My second concern this week is closer to home, and it is about our own credibility, not the market's. Our team raised a fair question: why do our bunker figures keep changing? The honest answer is that we were reporting single points from a market that trades across a US\$25–50/mt range on any given day, with a live drone war affecting a second major supply route on top of the first. Starting this issue, every price in this publication carries a stated cut-off and, where the underlying market itself trades a range, a range rather than a false point figure. We have also begun cross-checking Ship & Bunker against our Integr8 subscription rather than presenting one source as if it were the only one. A number that visibly reconciles across two sources is worth more to this business than a precise-looking number that cannot survive a second look.

None of this changes the operating instruction from previous issues: no Hormuz-linked nomination without owner-level authorisation and current-week war-risk confirmation, no STS counterparty accepted without a full blacklist and dark-period check. What has changed is that the bypass everyone was counting on has just shown it isn't one. Plan accordingly.

Capt. Dinesh Naidu KC

Founder & Chairman, DDS Marine Group

Publication Principle — Independent operational commentary based on publicly available and subscription market information (Ship & Bunker, Integr8 Fuels, oilprice.com), official statements, and reputable wire and trade reporting (Reuters, Bloomberg, Al Jazeera, the Wall Street Journal, Hellenic Shipping News) syndicated via named outlets, plus DDS Marine's own market intelligence. Every figure in this issue carries its source and, where applicable, a stated data cut-off.



This Week in Review

The week's principal developments, 12–18 September 2026

17 SEPTEMBER · REUTERS / OILPRICE.COM

Saudi East-West pipeline damage worse than first thought

Reuters reported three pumping stations along Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline were damaged in the prior week's drone attack, citing satellite imagery and industry sources; earlier assessments had identified only two. Repairs could take five to six weeks, though partial pumping may resume sooner. The system normally carries 4–5 million bpd of the route's 7 million bpd capacity. Aramco is targeting a partial restart within days per Bloomberg, and Yanbu inventories have fallen from ~21m barrels in July to below 15m barrels, per Kpler — at 3.5m bpd throughput, little more than four days of theoretical cover.

16 SEPTEMBER · OILPRICE.COM / BLOOMBERG

Tanker rates break US\$1 million a day for the first time

Bloomberg reported Gulf-pickup tanker rates as high as US\$1.035 million/day, citing Baltic Exchange data, with Gulf of Oman-to-China business (outside Hormuz) quoted around US\$644,000/day. Second-hand tanker values have moved sharply: a second-hand VLCC now reportedly commands roughly US\$182m against ~US\$130m for a newbuild, according to Argus; second-hand Suezmaxes and Aframaxs are similarly commanding premiums over new tonnage.

SEPTEMBER · WALL STREET JOURNAL

US investigates suspected cyberattack on two tankers near Gibraltar

US federal authorities are investigating a suspected cyberattack on two tankers — one carrying crude, one LNG — travelling from Europe toward the US Gulf Coast, after both were flagged for inspection on arrival in August. The incidents are believed to have originated near Gibraltar, a strait carrying roughly 300 vessels a day. US Coast Guard officials noted the safety risk of any system fault aboard a laden tanker.

18 SEPTEMBER · TIMES OF ISRAEL / IRANIAN STATE MEDIA

IRGC Navy strikes tanker attempting “illegal passage”

Iran's IRGC Navy said it struck a Togo-flagged oil tanker attempting what it called an unauthorised passage through the Strait of Hormuz; the vessel caught fire and came to a halt. Separately, Windward's tracking shows 12 vessels transited the Strait on 16 September — double the prior day's six — with three VLCCs identified crossing dark and riding high (ballast condition).

SEPTEMBER · OILPRICE.COM

Congress sends Russia-Iran sanctions bill to Trump; China presses Iran on the Houthis

The US House passed legislation authorising tariffs of up to 100% on countries including China and India that continue buying Russian energy. Separately, oilprice.com reports China has pressed Iran to rein in Houthi activity as Gulf tensions weigh on regional trade. The IEA reported global observed oil inventories fell 95 million barrels in August — a cumulative 507 million barrel drawdown since February, or roughly 2.8 million bpd.



Data Integrity & Methodology

Why our numbers move, and what we are changing from this issue on

Our own team flagged, correctly, that bunker and freight figures in recent issues have looked inconsistent from one day to the next. They have — because the underlying market moves within a wide daily range, and because different licensed sources publish different snapshots of it. This section sets out how we now handle that, rather than leaving readers to guess.

Four Rules, Applied From This Issue

Rule	What It Means Here
1. Stated cut-off	Every issue now states the exact data cut-off on its dashboard. This issue: Friday 18 September 2026 . A figure is only ever valid as of that moment.
2. Ranges, not points	Where our source itself publishes a daily High/Low, we report that range plus the index close — e.g. Singapore VLSFO US\$900–928/mt (index 913.50) — instead of a single number that implies more precision than the market actually offers.
3. Dual-source cross-check	Where we hold more than one subscription or source for the same benchmark, we show both and disclose the variance rather than picking one silently. See Global Oil Market, below.
4. Contract month stated	Crude and product quotes will state the delivery/contract month where it materially affects comparability — front-month WTI and a forward month are not the same number.

Worked example this issue: *Ship & Bunker's Friday index puts Singapore VLSFO at 913.50, inside a US\$900–927.50 daily range. Our Integr8 subscription's Thursday indication was 935. Neither figure is wrong — one is a same-day index close, the other a broker's early indication from the previous session. Reporting both, with dates, is more useful to a reader making a bunkering decision than silently averaging them or picking whichever number looks cleaner.*

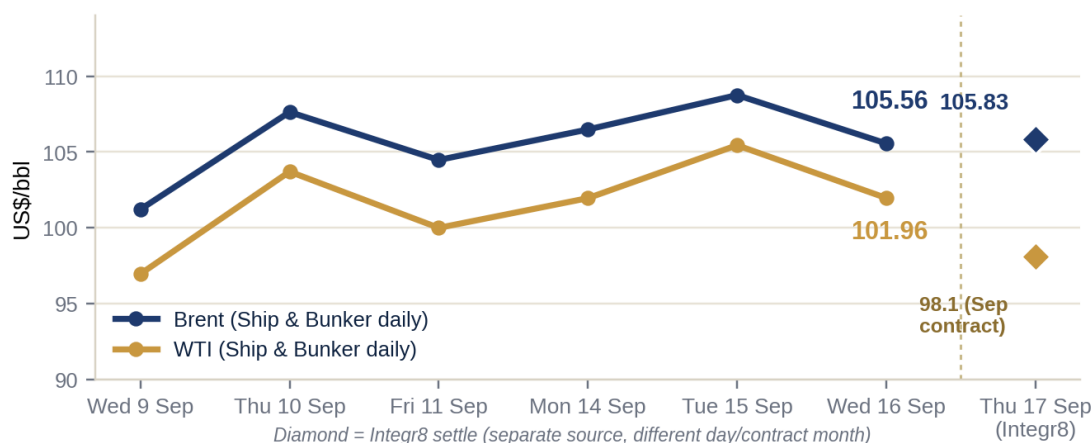
What This Does Not Change

DDS does not reproduce Baltic Exchange's proprietary index values, and freight sentiment continues to be expressed as an independent 1–5 DDS score rather than a licensed benchmark (see DDS Freight Market Monitor). Where a Baltic Exchange-derived figure is reported by a named wire service — for example, Bloomberg's reporting on Gulf tanker rates — DDS may cite that as news, attributed to the wire service, in the same way any other syndicated fact is cited.

Global Oil Market

Dual-source comparison — Ship & Bunker daily series vs. Integr8 Fuels indication, cut-off Friday 18 September 2026

Indicator	Ship & Bunker	Integr8 Fuels	Reading
Brent crude	US\$105.56/bbl (16 Sep close)	US\$105.83 (17 Sep settle, Oct contract)	Sources agree closely; both sessions after the pipeline damage was confirmed.
WTI crude	US\$101.96/bbl (16 Sep close)	US\$98.10 (17 Sep, Sep contract)	Different contract months — not directly comparable; Integr8's own forward curve shows Oct at 95.79.
Brent 9–16 Sep range	US\$101.21–108.75/bbl	—	Six-session range; peak followed the 15 Sep pipeline confirmation.



Brent and WTI, Ship & Bunker daily close vs. Integr8 settle. Diamond markers are a different source and, for WTI, a different contract month.

Market Interpretation

Brent has held in a US\$101–109 range over the past week, with the high point following confirmation that Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline had suffered worse damage than first assessed. Saxo Bank's Ole Hansen noted this week that Brent near US\$110 “understates the severity of the current physical squeeze,” pointing to Dated Brent above US\$130 and diesel above US\$200 as the more accurate signals of physical scarcity. US diesel and gasoline have both reached record highs even as the US remains a net distillate exporter, because global shortages are pulling American barrels into the world market.

The Federal Reserve raised its benchmark rate this week for the first time since 2023, citing renewed inflationary pressure — a direct line from Gulf supply disruption to US monetary policy.

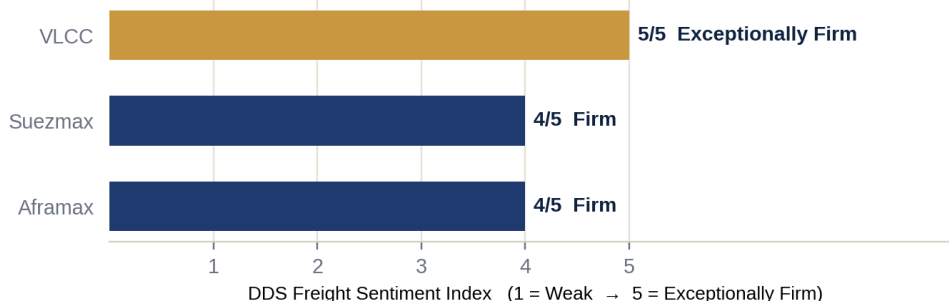
DDS BASE CASE — With a second major supply route now impaired alongside continued Hormuz disruption, we see Brent holding above US\$100 with a realistic path toward US\$115–120 if the pipeline repair slips beyond six weeks or a further attack occurs. A sustained move back below US\$95 would require both a Hormuz de-escalation and a confirmed, complete pipeline restoration — neither of which is currently in view.

Commercial effect on shipping: Treat any voyage estimate built before 15 September as stale on fuel, war-risk and freight simultaneously. The Saudi pipeline outage is a new, independent cost driver on top of the Hormuz premium already priced into recent issues.



Crude Tanker Market

VLCC, Suezmax and Aframax — DDS directional assessment, week ending 18 September 2026



DDS Freight Sentiment Index — DDS Marine's own analytical assessment. Not a third-party benchmark.

Segment	DDS Market Tone	Trend	Primary Driver
VLCC	5 / 5 — Exceptionally Firm	▲ ▲ Strong increase	Gulf pickups reportedly exceeding US\$1m/day; willing tonnage acutely scarce
Suezmax	5 / 5 — Exceptionally Firm	▲ ▲ Strong increase	Saudi spot cargo surge and East-West outage pulling demand toward seaborne routes
Aframax	4 / 5 — Firm	▲ Increase	Second-hand tonnage premium reducing available chartered supply

DDS Market Read

VLCC. Middle East Gulf VLCC business has moved from firm to exceptionally firm. Bloomberg's reporting (citing Baltic Exchange data) of Gulf-pickup rates as high as US\$1.035m/day is the clearest single data point of the week; Gulf of Oman-to-China business at roughly US\$644,000/day shows the premium extends even to voyages that avoid Hormuz outright.

Suezmax. Newly promoted to exceptionally firm this issue. Saudi Arabia's decision to sell up to 20 million barrels on the spot market, with delivery via STS outside the Strait, is pulling meaningful seaborne demand into a segment that normally tracks Atlantic and West African trade more than Gulf risk.

Aframax. Firm. The second-hand tonnage premium reported by Argus — used Suezmaxes at ~US\$130m and used Aframaxes at ~US\$95m, both above newbuild pricing — is a structural signal that owners expect today's conditions to persist long enough to justify buying rather than waiting for a newbuild delivery slot two to three years out.

DDS VIEW — *The buy-versus-build signal in second-hand values is, in our view, the more durable indicator this week than the spot rate spike itself. A spot rate can normalise within days of a ceasefire headline; a decision to pay a premium for existing steel reflects a multi-year view of the risk environment.*

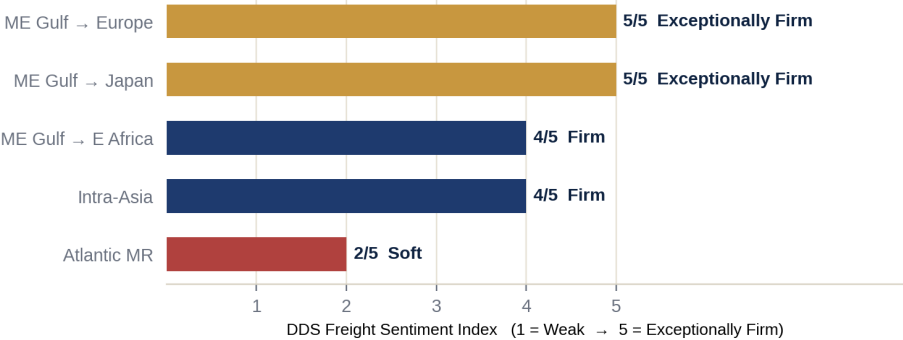
- Re-run voyage economics against a US\$1m/day Gulf benchmark, not last month's assumptions.
- Where chartering is not urgent, weigh acquisition against charter given the second-hand premium.
- Track Saudi spot-cargo STS volumes as a leading indicator of Gulf congestion.

Source basis: Bloomberg/Baltic Exchange (cited as news), Argus (cited via oilprice.com), market-reported fixtures and DDS Marine operational/commercial intelligence. Directional only.



Clean & Product Tankers

DDS Clean Tanker Signal — directional assessment, week ending 18 September 2026



DDS Freight Sentiment Index — DDS Marine's own analytical assessment. Not a third-party benchmark.

Trade	DDS Score	Trend	DDS Assessment
ME Gulf → Europe	5 / 5	▲ ▲	Diesel scarcity and record US/EU product prices pulling barrels long-haul
ME Gulf → Japan	5 / 5	▲	Tight willing tonnage, Gulf risk premium intact
ME Gulf → East Africa	4 / 5	▲	Regional disruption supporting rates
Intra-Asia	4 / 5	▬ Steady	Healthy underlying Pacific demand
Atlantic MR	3 / 5	▲ Improving	Diesel crunch lifting Atlantic product values off recent lows

DDS Market Read

Diesel is the story. Goldman Sachs and Kpler both flagged further upside in gasoline and diesel this week; US diesel is at record highs despite the US remaining a net exporter, as global shortages pull American barrels abroad — lifting product tanker earnings on both sides of the Atlantic, not just the Gulf.

Middle East Gulf. Clean tanker enquiry out of the Gulf remains very firm, with LR2/LR1 owners pricing in transit and insurance risk on top of already-strong product demand.

Atlantic MR. Moved up from Issue 007’s soft reading — record diesel pricing in the US and Europe is providing genuine underlying support, distinct from the Gulf risk premium driving the dirty complex.

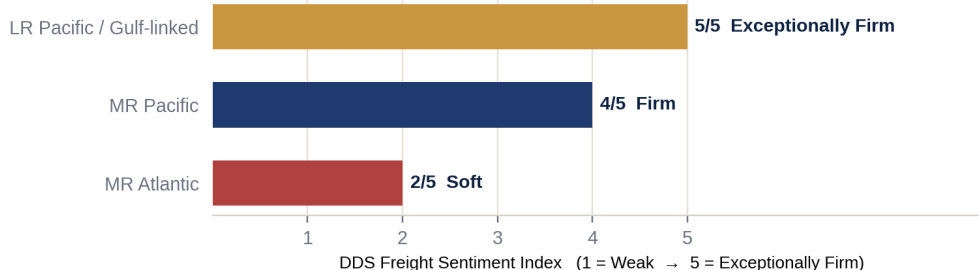
DDS VIEW — *This is a rare week where Atlantic and Pacific clean markets are both firming for different reasons: Gulf risk premium in the East, diesel scarcity in the West. Owners should not assume the two will move together going forward — a Gulf de-escalation would compress the Eastern premium without necessarily easing the diesel-driven Atlantic strength.*

Source basis: oilprice.com (Goldman Sachs, Kpler commentary), public reporting and DDS Marine operational/commercial intelligence. Directional only.



Pacific / Atlantic Product Tanker Split

DDS directional comparison — no third-party benchmark reproduced



DDS Freight Sentiment Index — DDS Marine's own analytical assessment. Not a third-party benchmark.

Market	DDS Tone	Trend	Commercial Reading
LR Pacific / Gulf-linked	5 / 5 — Very Firm	▲ ▲	Gulf risk premium plus diesel scarcity, compounding
MR Pacific	4 / 5 — Firm	▬ Steady	Consistent intra-Asia demand
MR Atlantic	3 / 5 — Improving	▲ Improving	Diesel-driven recovery off Issue 007's low

A Narrower Gap, for a New Reason

The Pacific/Atlantic split that widened sharply in Issue 007 has narrowed slightly this week — not because Gulf-linked strength has eased, but because Atlantic MR has genuinely improved on the back of record Western diesel pricing. That is a healthier narrowing than one driven by Gulf de-escalation would be, since it reflects two independent demand stories rather than one collapsing premium.

DDS VIEW — Do not read this week's narrower gap as a sign Gulf risk is easing. It is not. Compare net voyage economics after war-risk, bunkers and positioning time on any Gulf-linked fixture before assuming the two basins are now offering comparable risk-adjusted returns.

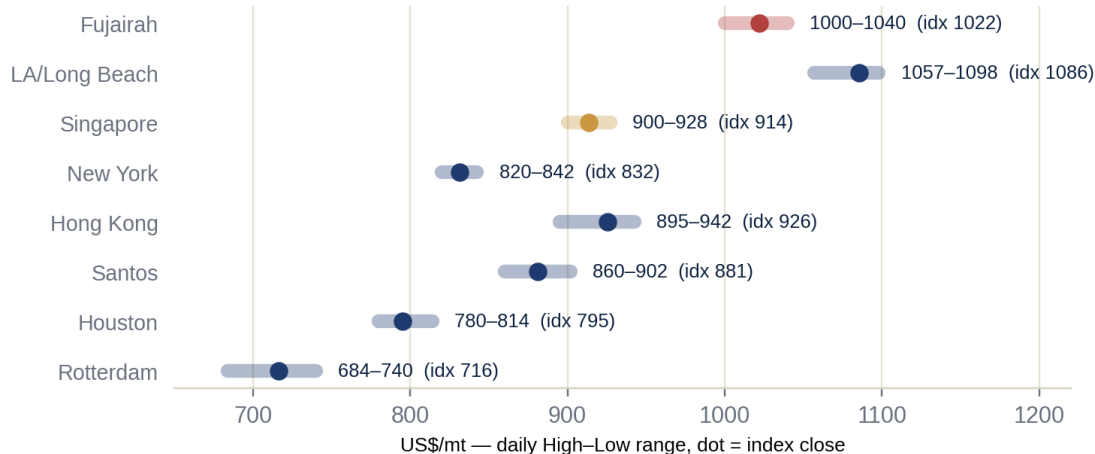
Source basis: public reporting, market-reported fixtures and DDS Marine operational/commercial intelligence. Directional only.



Bunker Market — Singapore & Global Benchmark

Ranges, not points — Ship & Bunker daily High/Low/Index, cut-off Friday 18 September 2026

Grade / Hub	Range	Index Close	Day Change
Singapore VLSFO	US\$900.00–927.50	US\$913.50	–US\$3.00
Fujairah VLSFO	US\$1,000.00–1,040.00	US\$1,022.00	–US\$6.00
Singapore MGO	US\$1,419.00–1,490.00	US\$1,448.00	–US\$16.00
Fujairah MGO	US\$1,650.00–1,765.00	US\$1,727.00	–US\$13.00
Singapore IFO380	US\$720.00–750.00	US\$736.00	–US\$28.00



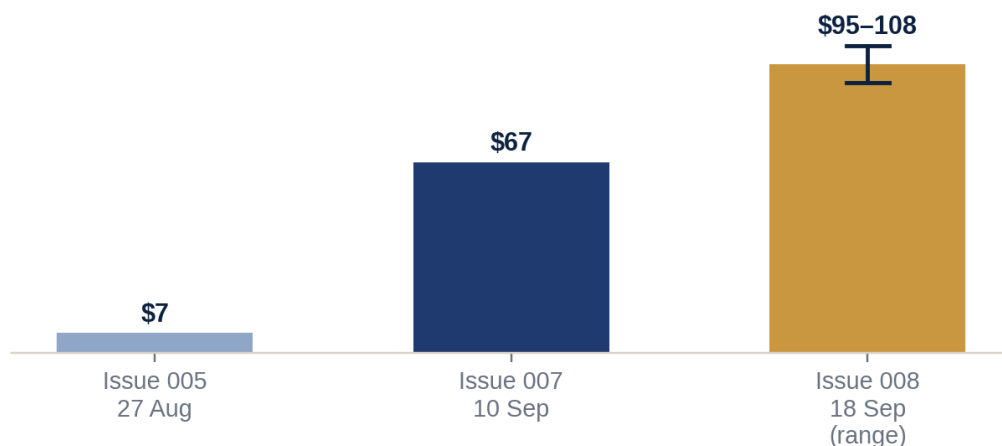
VLSFO High–Low range by hub with index close, Ship & Bunker, Friday 18 September 2026.

The Fujairah Premium Has Widened Further

Fujairah VLSFO's premium over Singapore, which we reported at US\$67/mt in Issue 007, has widened to **US\$95–108/mt** depending on source: US\$108.50/mt on the Ship & Bunker index (1,022.00 vs. 913.50), or US\$95/mt on our Integr8 cross-check (1,030 vs. 935, Thursday indications). Both sources agree on the direction and the broad magnitude even though the exact figure differs — which is itself the point of showing both.

Despite the widening Gulf premium, the underlying complex actually **softened** this week: the Global 20 Ports Average VLSFO eased to US\$891.50/mt (–US\$10.00) and the Global 4 Ports Average to US\$862.00/mt (–US\$9.00). APAC firmed marginally to US\$989.50 (+US\$4.50) while EMEA and the Americas both eased. The story is not "bunkers are rising" — it is "the Gulf risk premium is the only thing rising, against an otherwise softer complex."

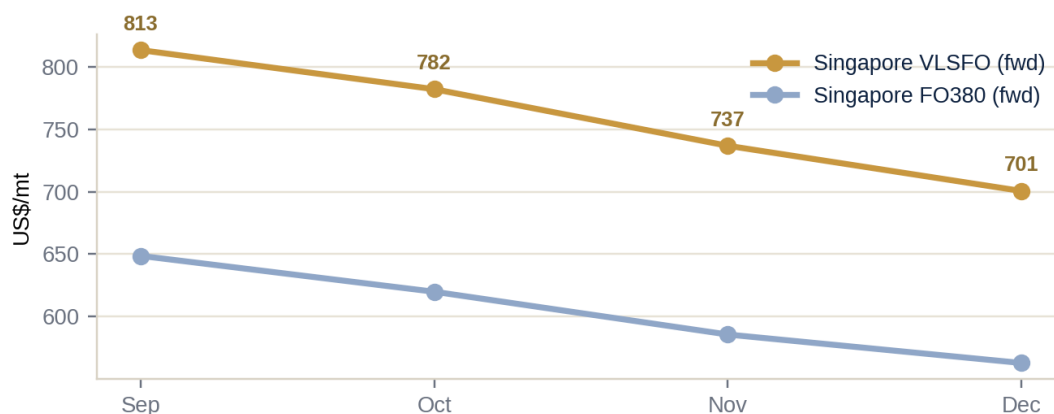
Fujairah VLSFO premium over Singapore, US\$/mt



Fujairah–Singapore VLSFO premium across the last three issues. Issue 008 shown as a range across two sources.

Compliance cost note: EUA held broadly steady at €85.22 (+€0.31), with the EUA-VLSFO equivalent at US\$315.79/mt. State it explicitly in bunker and freight clauses for any EU-linked call.

Forward Curve: The Complex Expects to Soften



Integr8 Fuels forward indications, Singapore VLSFO and FO380, Sep–Dec 2026. Not a same-day figure — a forward curve.

Integr8's own forward curve has Singapore VLSFO falling from US\$813/mt in September to US\$700/mt by December — a genuinely different signal from this week's Gulf-driven spot spike. Read together with the softer global average above, the forward curve suggests the market currently prices today's Gulf premium as temporary rather than structural, even though the Saudi pipeline outage itself may take five to six weeks to resolve. We would treat that gap between the spot story and the forward curve as worth watching rather than resolving in either direction this issue.



Geopolitical & Route Risk

Two chokepoints, one drone war — Hormuz and the Saudi East-West pipeline

Event	Detail	Commercial Consequence
Saudi pipeline damage	Three pumping stations confirmed damaged (Reuters); repairs 5–6 weeks; Aramco targets partial restart within days.	Removes the market's main Hormuz-bypass route; forces more Gulf-transit and STS volume.
Saudi spot sales	Up to 20m barrels sold on spot market this week for Sep/Oct loading, delivered via STS outside Hormuz (Bloomberg).	Adds seaborne demand and logistical complexity; a new, direct driver of Suezmax and STS activity.
Hormuz transits	Windward: 12 vessels transited 16 Sep (double the prior day's 6); 3 VLCCs tracked dark and inbound in ballast.	Traffic remains thin and irregular; dark-transiting tankers are a live counterparty-screening risk.
Togo-flagged tanker struck	IRGC Navy says it struck a tanker attempting "illegal passage" on 18 Sep; vessel caught fire and stopped.	Confirms attacks on merchant shipping are continuing, not de-escalating.

The Bypass Becomes a Casualty

Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline exists specifically so the kingdom does not have to send all of its crude through Hormuz. This week that logic broke down. Reuters reported three pumping stations damaged, worse than the two-station assessment made after the initial attack, with repairs estimated at five to six weeks. Yanbu's buffer stocks have fallen from roughly 21 million barrels in July to under 15 million, per Kpler — at current throughput, barely four days of theoretical cover. Aramco is racing to restore around half of capacity within days by bypassing the damaged sections, but full service is not expected soon.

The market's response has been to route around the routing-around: Saudi Arabia is reportedly selling as much as 20 million barrels on the spot market this week, with delivery via ship-to-ship transfers outside the Strait — avoiding sending buyers' own tankers deep into the Gulf, but adding a further layer of STS activity and cost precisely where our own operational focus sits. Japanese refiners have separately rushed to secure Oman crude as an alternative to the shut pipeline.

A Widening List, Not a Shrinking One

Windward's tracking shows Iran's Persian Gulf Strait Authority has issued blacklist tranches on 24 August, 2 September and 14 September, taking the list to 78 vessels — up from the 45 reported in Issue 006. Windward's analysis found the listed vessels had all used either the unauthorised southern corridor through Omani waters or Iran's own northern corridor without paying tolls; inclusion on the list does not appear to have stopped any of them continuing to trade in the region.

DDS RISK LEVEL: CRITICAL (unchanged). A second major supply route is now impaired alongside continued Hormuz disruption; tanker rates and second-hand values are both at levels we have not previously recorded; and a widening blacklist has not measurably changed vessel behaviour. DDS recommends treating every Gulf-linked nomination — pipeline-adjacent or Hormuz-linked — as an owner-level decision, and pricing STS exposure into every Saudi-origin spot cargo now moving outside the Strait.



Sanctions & Compliance Watch

Actionable controls for fixtures and STS operations

Developments — Week Ending 18 September 2026

Blacklist grows to 78 vessels: Iran's Persian Gulf Strait Authority has issued three further blacklist tranches since Issue 006 (24 Aug, 2 Sep, 14 Sep), taking the total to 78 tankers. Windward's analysis found the pattern common to all of them: unauthorised use of the southern (Omani) corridor, or use of the northern corridor without paying Iran's asserted tolls. Listing has not visibly changed any vessel's trading pattern.

Congress sends Russia-Iran sanctions bill to Trump: the US House passed legislation authorising tariffs of up to 100% on countries, including China and India, that continue importing Russian energy. If signed, this widens the sanctions surface our counterparties may be exposed to well beyond Iran-specific designations.

Cyberattack investigation: the Wall Street Journal reports US authorities are investigating a suspected cyberattack on two tankers near Gibraltar. This is a new risk category for our screening — not just who owns or has traded with a vessel, but whether its systems have been compromised in a way that could affect safe navigation.

Direct operational implication for DDS: a growing blacklist that does not change behaviour means screening cannot rely on the list alone deterring bad actors — it must actively catch them. Dark-period and corridor-use analysis (see below) is now the more reliable signal than blacklist status by itself.

Control	Minimum Action
Iran blacklist screening	Check every nominated vessel <i>and</i> its STS counterparties against the current 78-vessel list before fixing or accepting any STS job.
Corridor-use review	New this issue: flag any vessel with a recent southern (Omani) or unauthorised northern-corridor transit, even if not yet blacklisted — Windward's analysis shows this is the common thread across listed vessels.
AIS dark-period review	Review full AIS history for gaps; escalate any vessel with an extended dark period, particularly where the declared destination is in our region.
War-risk confirmation	Obtain current-week war-risk quotes before nominating Gulf-linked tonnage; terms from before 15 September are stale given the pipeline development.
Record preservation	Keep screenshots, screening evidence, approvals, emails, SOF and operational instructions in the job file.

Editorial & Verification Note: *DDS Marine Group publishes vessel names and designation detail only where attributable to a named primary source. Readers should verify any specific vessel against the current Iran blacklist, the OFAC SDN list and their own screening provider before acting.*



Incident & Risk Watch

Confirmed and declared incidents, 12–18 September 2026

Vessel / Target	Detail	Source	Date
Unnamed Togo-flagged tanker	Struck by IRGC Navy while attempting what Iran called an unauthorised Hormuz passage; caught fire and stopped.	Iranian state media / Times of Israel	18 Sep
Two unnamed tankers	Suspected cyberattack near Gibraltar en route to US Gulf Coast; flagged for inspection on August arrival, one carrying crude, one LNG.	Wall Street Journal	Reported this week; incident in August
Saudi East-West pipeline	Three pumping stations confirmed damaged by drone attack; not a vessel incident, but the week's most consequential infrastructure attack.	Reuters	Confirmed 17 Sep, attack the prior week
3 VLCCs (unnamed)	Tracked transiting dark and in ballast condition, riding high, on 16 September.	Windward	16 Sep

Pattern assessment: This week's confirmed incidents span three distinct threat categories simultaneously — kinetic (the Togo-flagged tanker strike), infrastructure (the pipeline), and cyber (the Gibraltar investigation). A screening or compliance programme built around only one of these will miss the others.

What We Are Watching

- Whether Saudi Arabia's partial pipeline restart (targeted within days) materialises, and how much capacity it actually restores.
- Whether the WSJ's cyberattack investigation identifies a state or non-state actor, and whether further vessels are affected.
- Whether Windward's dark-VLCC pattern (three vessels, 16 Sep) recurs or was a one-off.
- P&I and war-risk underwriter guidance following the confirmed pipeline damage and the Gibraltar cyber investigation.

Ship Recycling & Demolition

Hellenic Shipping News's own front page this week describes the ship recycling market as having “remained trending higher, as has been the case over the past few weeks” — consistent with owners across the tanker segments favouring continued trading (and, per this issue's crude section, buying second-hand) over scrapping while freight remains this firm.



Southeast Asia & STS Operations

Malaysia · Singapore · Indonesia · Thailand · Vietnam — the Malacca-to-Pengerang corridor

Two developments this issue make our corridor's relative position stronger, and neither is Hormuz-specific. First, Singapore VLSFO now carries a US\$95–108/mt advantage over Fujairah, the widest gap we have recorded — a direct bunkering cost incentive for any vessel with routing flexibility. Second, Saudi Arabia's pivot toward spot sales and STS delivery outside Hormuz means more cargo is moving through exactly the kind of ship-to-ship operation this region, and this company, specialises in.

Market	Why It Matters This Week
Malaysia	Port Klang, Malacca, Muar, Linggi and the Johor STS/bunkering corridor. Growing Iran blacklist (78 vessels) and corridor-use risk mean every STS counterparty needs a fresh check, not a one-time one.
Singapore	VLSFO at US\$900–928/mt against Fujairah US\$1,000–1,040 — a widening cost advantage that should support bunkering demand here.
Indonesia	Batam and Karimun remain active in STS and bunkering; outer port limits require continued enhanced due diligence.
Thailand	Gulf of Thailand distribution continues to benefit from trade diversion as a secondary regional routing option.
Vietnam	Intra-Asia CPP demand steady; a bellwether for regional MR product tanker patterns.

STS & Marine-Services Operating Standard

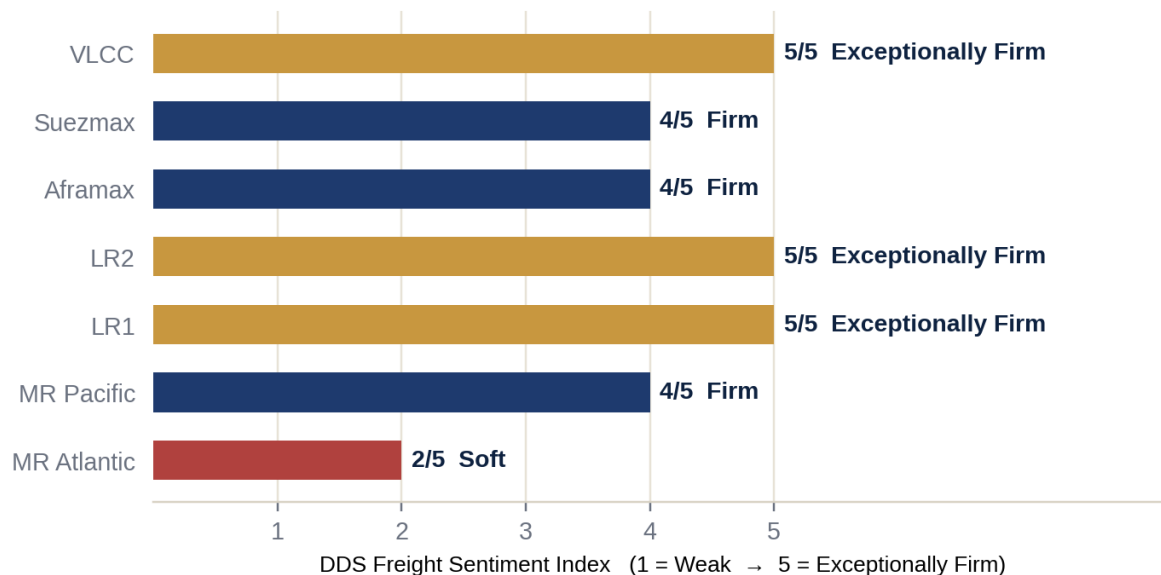
Operational Pillar	DDS Standard
Planning	Job-specific JPO, risk assessment, mooring plan, weather limits, communications plan and emergency response.
Vessel suitability	Compatibility review covering freeboard, manifold, fenders, hoses, mooring arrangement, vetting and cargo system.
Counterparty & identity	IMO verification; beneficial ownership; full AIS dark-period and corridor-use review; cargo-origin documentary chain; Iranian blacklist check on principals <i>and</i> STS counterparties.
Documentation	Accurate NOR, SOF, checklists, pumping records, delay evidence, photographs and final operation report.

DDS VIEW — *Saudi Arabia doing STS outside Hormuz to move spot cargo is, in effect, the same operational discipline we practise in this region every week — just under far more acute pressure. The lesson for us is not that our methods are being validated at a distance; it is that as STS volumes globally increase under crisis conditions, the standard our own execution is held to should rise with them, not stay where it was.*



DDS Freight Market Monitor

Independent DDS market sentiment — 1 = Weak | 2 = Soft | 3 = Balanced | 4 = Firm | 5 = Exceptionally Firm



DDS Freight Sentiment Index, 18 September 2026 — DDS Marine's own analytical assessment. Not a third-party benchmark.

Market	DDS Score	Trend	DDS Market Read
VLCC	5 / 5	▲ ▲	Gulf pickups reportedly >US\$1m/day; the acute end of the entire board this issue.
Suezmax	5 / 5	▲ ▲	Newly promoted on Saudi spot-sale/STS volume outside Hormuz.
Aframax	4 / 5	▲	Second-hand tonnage premium tightening available chartered supply.
LR2	5 / 5	▲	Gulf-origin long-haul plus diesel scarcity, compounding.
LR1	5 / 5	▲	Firm alongside LR2 on Gulf-linked employment.
MR Pacific	4 / 5	▬ Steady	Consistent intra-Asia product demand.
MR Atlantic	3 / 5	▲ Improving	Diesel-driven recovery off Issue 007's soft reading.

DDS MARKET SIGNAL — *This is the first issue where dirty and clean Gulf-linked tanker sentiment sit together at the top of our scale (5/5) at the same time as a genuine, independent product-market driver (the diesel crunch) is lifting Atlantic MR off its recent low. Two different stories are pushing rates up simultaneously; they should not be assumed to unwind together.*



DDS Gas & Regional Monitor

Market	DDS Tone	Trend	What DDS Is Watching
LPG	3 / 5 — Balanced	▬ Flat	Gulf LPG remains difficult to read where benchmark assessment is thin; US Gulf export business provides the clearer signal.
LNG	4 / 5 — Firm	▲	oilprice.com reports LNG prices could jump further as the Hormuz supply crunch persists; Asian demand is being pulled toward a second annual decline on price alone.
Intra-Asia CPP	4 / 5 — Firm	▬ Steady	Regional product movement supportive.
Singapore-linked clean	4 / 5 — Firm	▲	Widening bunker and routing advantage supports corridor interest.

Publication note: DDS scores are independent analytical opinions prepared for market intelligence purposes. They are not third-party benchmarks and should not be treated as executable freight quotations.

Editorial note: No new period/time-charter fixture data was available to DDS for this issue; the standing period-market section will return when fresh fixtures are confirmed.



Seven-Day Outlook: 12 – 18 September 2026

19 – 25 September 2026

Market	Base Case	Upside Risk	Downside Risk
Crude oil	Brent holds US\$100–110 while the Saudi pipeline remains impaired and Hormuz risk continues.	US\$115–120 if pipeline repair slips beyond six weeks or a further attack occurs.	Below US\$95 requires both a Hormuz de-escalation and a confirmed full pipeline restoration.
VLCC / Suezmax	Both segments hold at the top of our scale while Gulf-pickup rates remain above US\$1m/day and Saudi spot/STS volume continues.	Further owner withdrawal or a confirmed Saudi partial restart delay tightening the pool further.	A credible pipeline restart plus Hormuz de-escalation returning withheld tonnage.
Bunkers	Global average softens further while the Fujairah–Singapore premium persists or widens; forward curve continues pointing down into Q4.	Wider Gulf premium if Saudi bunkering is further disrupted.	Premium narrows if the pipeline repair accelerates or crude reverses broadly.
Southeast Asia	Corridor importance rises further as both Hormuz and the Saudi bypass remain constrained; STS and bunkering demand grows.	Further redirected Saudi spot cargo and STS volume into the corridor.	A credible resolution on both fronts reducing the diversion premium.

Watch List

- Whether Aramco's targeted partial pipeline restart (within days) materialises and how much capacity it actually restores.
- Whether Gulf tanker rates hold above US\$1m/day or prove a short-lived spike.
- Whether the WSJ's tanker cyberattack investigation identifies further affected vessels.
- Whether Iran issues further blacklist tranches beyond the current 78 vessels.
- Whether the diesel crunch continues lifting Atlantic MR independently of Gulf-linked sentiment.
- Whether next issue's Ship & Bunker and Integr8 figures continue to reconcile within a sensible range.

DDS CONCLUSION — Issue 007 showed merchant shipping under direct attack. Issue 008 shows the market's own safety valve — Saudi Arabia's Hormuz bypass — failing at the same time, with tanker rates and second-hand values responding at levels we have not recorded before. We have also changed how we report: every figure in this issue carries a stated cut-off and, where the market itself trades a range, a range rather than a single misleadingly precise number. That change does not make the underlying situation any calmer, but it should make this publication a more reliable basis for decisions inside a genuinely volatile week.



Methodology, Sources & Disclaimer

ISSUE 008 — DATA CUT-OFF: FRIDAY 18 SEPTEMBER 2026

DDS Weekly Maritime Intelligence combines public information, subscription market data, market-reported fixtures, official releases and operator-focused analysis. Every price now carries a stated cut-off and, where the source publishes a daily range, a range rather than a single point figure; where DDS holds more than one source for a benchmark, both are shown with variance disclosed. DDS freight commentary is independent analysis; DDS sentiment indicators are DDS Marine's own assessment, not third-party benchmarks.

Source	Information Used
Ship & Bunker (shipandbunker.com), cut-off 18 Sep 2026	VLSFO/MGO/IFO380 High/Low/Index across eight hubs; regional and global averages; EUA compliance costs; Brent/WTI daily close series 9–16 Sep.
Integr8 Fuels Daily Market Report, 17 Sep 2026 (DDS subscription)	Cross-check for Singapore/Fujairah VLSFO and MGO; Brent/WTI settle; forward curve.
oilprice.com, 15–18 Sep 2026	Saudi pipeline and Yanbu inventory data (via Reuters/Bloomberg/Kpler); tanker rate and second-hand value reporting (via Bloomberg/Argus); diesel-crunch and Fed rate commentary.
Reuters / Bloomberg (via oilprice.com)	Three damaged pumping stations on the pipeline; Aramco restart timeline; Saudi spot/STS sales; Gulf and Gulf of Oman–China tanker rates, attributed to Baltic Exchange data.
Wall Street Journal (via oilprice.com)	Suspected cyberattack investigation on two tankers near Gibraltar.
Windward Daily Intelligence	Hormuz transit counts (12 vessels, 16 Sep); dark/ballast VLCC tracking; blacklist analysis (78 vessels).
Iranian state media / Times of Israel	IRGC Navy strike on a Togo-flagged tanker, 18 Sep.
Hellenic Shipping News Worldwide	Ship recycling market commentary.
DDS Marine market intelligence	Broker quotes, open tonnage and cargo enquiries underpinning the DDS Freight Sentiment Index.

What's changed since Issue 007 (11 September 2026): Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline — the main Hormuz bypass — is confirmed damaged at three pumping stations, repairs estimated at five to six weeks. Gulf tanker rates have broken US\$1m/day for the first time on record, and second-hand values now exceed newbuild pricing. A suspected cyberattack on two tankers near Gibraltar is under US investigation, and Iran's blacklist has grown to 78 vessels. The Fujairah–Singapore VLSFO premium has widened from US\$67/mt to US\$95–108/mt even as the broader complex softened. DDS has introduced a standing Data Integrity & Methodology practice: stated cut-offs, ranges instead of points, dual-source cross-checks, and contract-month disclosure. Risk level remains CRITICAL.

Disclaimer — This publication is for general information only and is not investment, legal, sanctions, insurance, technical, navigational or chartering advice. Market indications can change without notice. Users must independently verify all data and obtain appropriate professional advice before acting. DDS Marine Group accepts no liability for decisions made solely on the basis of this publication.

DDS MARINE GROUP

Maritime Intelligence | STS Operations | Marine Advisory | Energy Solutions

ISSUE 008 — 18 SEPTEMBER 2026 | Prepared for professional circulation | Malaysia / Southeast Asia focus